

GO · VARIANT 1 OF 2

Toroidal Go

11×11
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

TOROIDAL GO

Standard Go played on a board where edges wrap around horizontally and vertically. No corners, no edges, no joseki. Every group floats. Active tournament community since 2012 with 1,400+ recorded games.

SETUP

Board: A grid where the far left connects to the far right, and the top connects to the bottom. Every intersection has exactly four neighbours. The standard size is 11x11, though 9x9 through 25x25 are also played.

Stones: Standard Go stones. Black plays first.

RULES

All standard Go rules apply (placement, capture by surrounding, ko rule, no suicide) with one modification:

- ♦ **Wraparound adjacency:** Each intersection on the far left is adjacent to the corresponding intersection on the far right. Each intersection on the top is adjacent to the corresponding intersection on the bottom. The surface is topologically a torus.
- ♦ **No edges or corners:** Every intersection has exactly four neighbours. There are no edge or corner positions anywhere on the board.
- ♦ **Scoring:** Standard area (Chinese) or territory (Japanese) scoring applies. White receives 4.5 komi on an 11x11 board.

STRATEGY

- ♦ All groups are floating from the opening move. Corner joseki (standard sequences) do not exist.
- ♦ Making two eyes to live is harder because there are no natural safe structures at board edges.
- ♦ Splitting the opponent into two separate eyeless groups and attacking one is a primary strategy.
- ♦ Territorial frameworks must be small on 11x11; forcing the opponent into thin shape is key.

VISUALISATION

Most software displays 3-4 extra lines around the main grid as duplicates of the opposite edges (shown in a different background colour). On a physical 19x19 board, 11x11 toroidal Go can be played using the inner 11x11 area with the outer lines serving as wraparound reference.

TOURNAMENT HISTORY

On LittleGolem, an ongoing ladder tournament has 21 players. A previous tournament ran from 2012 to 2020: 129 players, 1,497 games, 138 rounds, average 76 moves per game. The European Go Congress has hosted toroidal Go tournaments, most recently in 2023.

ATTRIBUTION

Variant with active competitive community. Source: Sensei's Library (OPL 1.0).

GO · VARIANT 2 OF 2

Phantom Go

9×9 or 13×13
BOARD

2 + referee
PLAYERS

PHANTOM GO

Fog-of-war Go. Players cannot see opponent stones. A referee mediates all moves and announces captures. Deduction replaces reading. Played on 9x9 or 13x13 boards.

SETUP

Equipment: Three boards are needed: one for each player and one for the referee. Players sit back-to-back so neither can see the other's board. The referee stands between them with the master board showing all stones.

Board size: Usually 9x9 or 13x13.

Stones: Standard Go stones. Black plays first.

RULES

All standard Go rules apply (placement, capture, ko, no suicide) with the following modifications:

- ♦ **Hidden information:** Players can only see their own stones. Opponent stones are invisible.
- ♦ **Turn structure:** A player places a stone on their own board. The referee checks legality on the master board. If legal, the referee copies it to the master board and announces the result. If illegal, the player tries again (it remains their turn).
- ♦ **Passing:** A player may pass. The referee announces passes to both players.

ANNOUNCEMENTS (COMMON RULES)

- ♦ **Illegal moves:** The referee says only "Illegal move" without stating why.
- ♦ **Captures:** When a capture occurs, the referee announces "Black/White has captured the following stones" and points out exactly which stones were captured to both players.
- ♦ **Atari:** The referee announces atari only if the stones were not already in atari before the move. The referee says "Black/White puts White/Black into atari" but does NOT say which specific stones are in atari.

ANNOUNCEMENTS (HAMBURG RULES)

The Hamburg variant differs in two ways:

- ♦ The referee **reveals why** a move is illegal (occupied by own stone, occupied by opponent stone, suicide, or ko) rather than just saying "Illegal move."
- ♦ The referee does **NOT** point out which specific stones were captured (only announces the number).

This creates different deduction dynamics: you learn more from failed moves but less from opponent captures.

WIN CONDITION

Standard Go scoring applies. The game ends when both players pass consecutively. Territory or area scoring determines the winner.

STRATEGY

- ♦ Information is the scarcest resource. Every failed move attempt reveals something about the board state.
- ♦ Playing cautiously (avoiding illegal move attempts) preserves secrecy but risks falling behind.
- ♦ Captures are the primary source of confirmed information about opponent stone positions.
- ♦ On 9x9 boards, the reduced space makes deduction more tractable.

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Variant with active competitive community. Source: Sensei's Library (OPL 1.0).